Just as the BJP reached out to Dalits and OBCs in UP by reserving positions for them at the booth and district levels, after 2014, it instituted a gender-based reservation system in the state as part of an organisational overhaul. Twenty-five per cent of posts were reserved for women in BJP executive councils (karyakarani) set up in each booth and district. In these twenty-one-member councils, five seats were reserved for women and two each for SCs and OBCs, at every level of the party. When I met up with a group of BJP district-level leaders in Mathura in July 2020, they told me this was a big turning point for the party.[83] Initially, the party found it very difficult to fill these women's quotas, so it relied on relatives of local leaders. As a BJP district general secretary explained to me. 'If you want to fill five women, then you make someone's wife, someone's sister and so on. If we had to choose five women, then four we did only to fill the quota, but one woman that was genuinely new. That one woman turned into ten, but those ten new ones came from that first one. They came slowly. They did not come together.' Just as with Dalits and OBCs, however, this reservation forced local party leaders to reach out to families that had never before voted BJP. 'If we talked to fifty people, then maybe five came in, but these five became the starting point for reaching out to others,' summed up Pradeep Goswami, BJP general secretary in Mathura.[84]

This move had a deep impact at the constituency voting-booth level. 'Elections are a kind of war and the mantra to win an election depends on 50 per cent planning and 50 per cent implementation on the pratyaksh [clearly visible] battlefield,' explains the BJP's *Mahila Morcha: Training Manual*, outlining its 'Mahila Booth Rachna' (Women's Booth Formation). 'Victory and defeat are dependent on booth planning.' This is why the quotas for women in voting booths were so crucial. Because 'in the end the final fight in an election is fought only at the booth'.[85] This is why, by the time of the Karnataka election of May 2018, Modi was directly telling party workers that the poll would be won on 'naari shakti'—woman power. As he told a gathering of the BJP's Karnataka Mahila Morcha:[86]